Grassroots Conversations

IF YOU HEAR THIS

“I’m independent / both parties are the same.”

In Arizona, Independent, Party Not Designated (PND), and Other are treated the same. This page is for when you hear that someone doesn’t want to pick a party, or that both parties are the same. Listen first. Talk from the heart. Then use the bridge that fits the setting.

Short Bridge

Use this after you’ve listened and let them know you heard them. It’s one or two sentences that move the talk from the national noise to something local they care about, and it ends with a question so they keep talking. If they open up, keep listening. If not, thank them and move on.

“A lot of people feel that way. Most people registered as independent, PND, or other still lean one direction and vote like partisans. I’m focused on results — costs and safer streets — not the drama. What’s hitting your family most right now?”

The Issue and Expanded Bridge

The facts behind the issue and a longer bridge, for when they want to keep talking.

The issue

Many independents, PND, and Other-registered voters say both parties look the same because national arguments dominate what they see. Data shows most people in these categories still lean toward one party and vote like partisans. Only a small slice is truly non-leaning.

Short background

In Arizona, Independent, Party Not Designated (PND), and Other are all treated as having no recognized party affiliation. Leaving the party field blank defaults to PND. Statewide, the “Other” category (dominated by PND and non-recognized designations) is the largest single group at roughly 35 percent. Yavapai County shows a substantial combined unaffiliated pool. Pew Research (2024) found independents nationally split 48–48 between the parties. Pure non-leaners are estimated at about 5–10 percent. Arizona’s open primary lets any independent, PND, or Other voter request a Republican ballot without re-registering. Locally the differences show up in measurable outcomes: waste cut before new taxes, first-responder support, water and roads with growth, and schools focused on basics and parental choice. Turnout in many local races is low enough that organized participation changes outcomes.

The bridge

“I hear you — a lot of people feel both sides argue more than they deliver. Most people registered independent, PND, or other still lean one way. On the things that hit us here — grocery bills, neighborhood safety, water with the growth — which of those is weighing on you most right now?” Listen, mirror, and offer one next step (registration check, one neighbor conversation, or covering one block). If the conversation is in a primary season, note that independents, PND, and Other voters can request a Republican ballot.
Close with ownership when it fits: “We are the they. What’s the one block or one person you’ll cover?”

Deeper Background

For your own preparation. You don’t need to recite this. It helps you understand why people feel this way and answer questions with confidence.

Why the claim appears

National media and social feeds reward conflict. Both parties are portrayed through the same high-volume frames, so many voters conclude they are interchangeable. The feeling is real even when most people registered as independent, PND, or Other are actually partisan leaners and local governance differences are visible in budgets, public-safety response, water policy, and school-board outcomes.

Supporting data and local context

- Arizona treats Independent, PND, and Other the same: no recognized party. PND is the default for blank party fields.
- Statewide “Other” (primarily PND and non-recognized) is the largest category at roughly 1.53 million / 35 percent (AZSOS October 2026).
- Pew Research (2024): independents voted 48 percent Republican, 48 percent Democrat.
- Pure non-leaners are estimated at about 5–10 percent. Most still lean and vote like partisans.
- Arizona open primary allows Independent, PND, and Other voters to request a Republican ballot.
- Yavapai County has a substantial combined unaffiliated pool. Local issues (water constraints with growth, housing affordability, neighborhood safety, school choice) remain the highest-yield entry points.

The perspective shift

“Both parties are the same” is often a reaction to national media volume, not a rejection of local results. Most people in the Independent / PND / Other categories already lean. Shifting the conversation to one measurable local outcome restores agency without requiring party loyalty. The person does not need to become a partisan; they only need to care about one concrete result and take one practical step.

2-Minute Two-Person Conversation

A sample conversation from start to finish. Practice it with a partner until it sounds like you.

Setting: Front porch or sidewalk. Neighbor has just said they are independent and both parties are the same.

Neighbor: I'm independent. Both parties are the same. I'm not sure any of it matters.
You: A lot of people feel that way. Most people registered independent, PND, or other still lean one direction and end up voting like partisans. What's hitting your family the hardest right now — groceries, neighborhood safety, water with the growth, or schools?
Neighbor: Groceries and the growth. Water and roads feel stretched.
You: Yeah, those show up in local decisions. A few hundred organized voters can change school board or city outcomes here. Arizona also lets independents, PND, and Other voters request a Republican ballot in the primary if they want. I'm not asking you to pick a team. Would you be willing to check one neighbor's registration or cover one block this month?
Neighbor: Maybe. Let me think about it.
You: No pressure. I'll follow up next week. We are the they. What's the one person you'd feel comfortable talking to?

Neighbors talking to neighbors. We are the they.